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SLATE CITATION LAB · THE HALF-LIFE OF AN AI CITATION

Half of this week's AI citations are gone in 11 days.

Brand mentions last 5.8× longer.

Google AI Mode · ChatGPT · Perplexity

40,281 AI answers · **14** weekly runs · **990** fixed prompts · **33** categories

Survival analysis on every cited URL, domain and named brand

Shiyam Sunder · CEO, Slate

swipe →

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METHOD

How we measured decay.

01 **Same prompts, every week**

990 fixed buyer prompts across 33 categories, run every Monday on Google AI Mode, ChatGPT, Perplexity. Answers collected from the consumer apps through data providers, not the APIs.

02 **Track every item's spell**

A spell is an unbroken run of weeks in which the same URL, domain or brand appears in the answer to the same prompt on the same engine.

03 **Strict rules for "gone"**

Gone = absent for 2 straight collected runs (one-week flickers don't count). A missing response is skipped, never counted as absent. Only spells that start after week 1 are used.

04 **Kaplan-Meier survival**

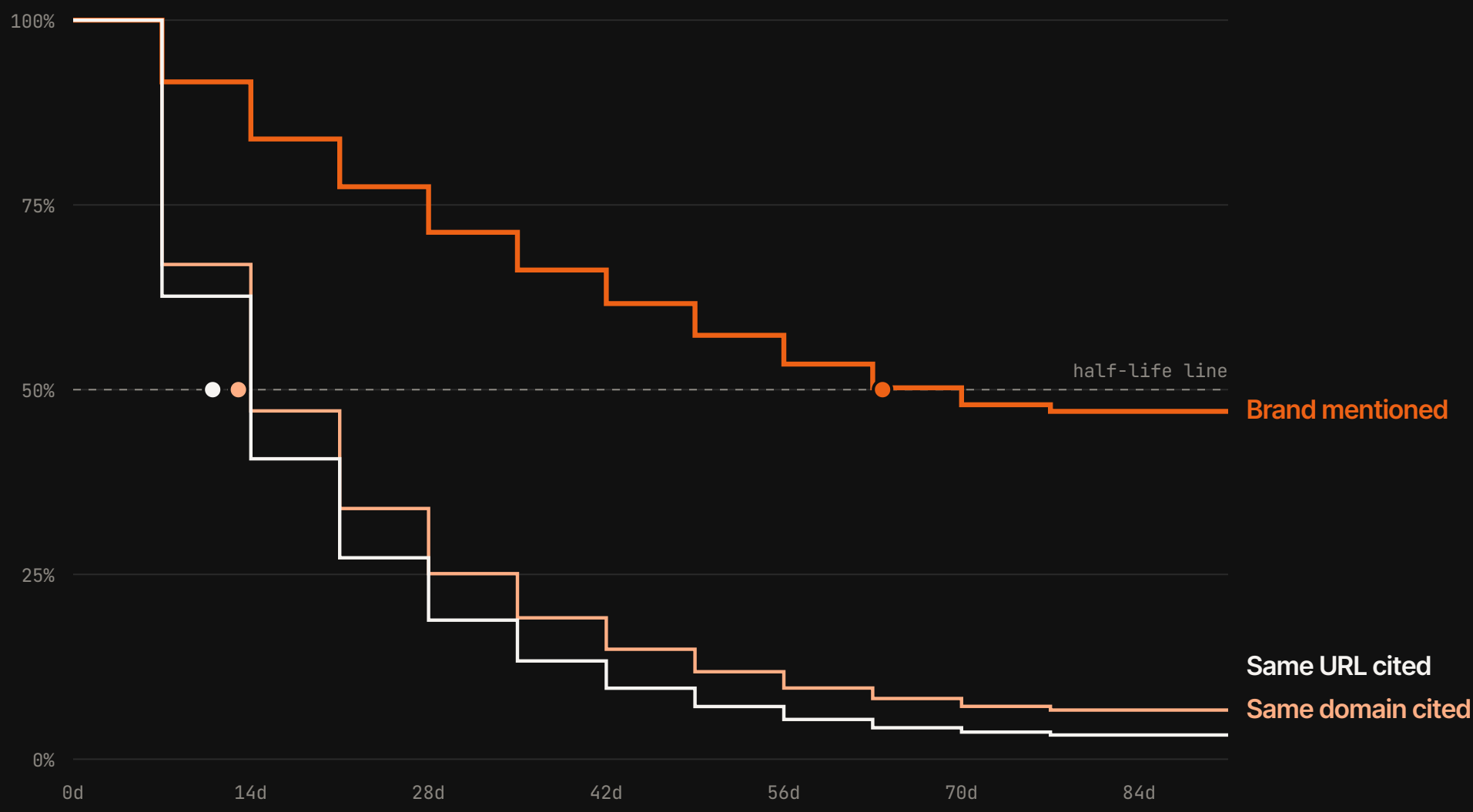
Half-life = median survival. Spells still alive at the last run are censored, not dropped. URL vs brand compared with a log-rank test.

→ 110,711 URL spells and 18,787 brand spells analysed.

FINDING 01 · THE DECAY CURVE

Citations fade in days. Brand mentions hold for weeks.

SHARE OF SPELLS STILL ALIVE · BY DAYS SINCE FIRST APPEARANCE



11d
half-life of a cited URL

13d
half-life of a cited domain

64d
half-life of a brand mention

→ Same answers, same prompts. What the engine says about you outlives the page it cited.

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FINDING 02 · WEEKLY CHURN

42% of cited URLs are replaced every single week.

42%
of URLs cited one week are gone the next

38%
of domains

11%
of brands

STILL PRESENT AFTER…

	URL	domain	brand
after 1 week	63%	67%	92%
after 2 weeks	41%	47%	84%
after 4 weeks	19%	25%	71%
after 8 weeks	5%	10%	54%

→ A single weekly snapshot of "cited pages" is mostly noise. A brand-level trend is mostly signal.

SlateIndex · 40,281 AI answers · 14 weekly runs · 2026-08-10 to 2026-11-09

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FINDING 03 · BY ENGINE

Every engine churns citations. None of them churn the shortlist.

HALF-LIFE IN DAYS · URL VS BRAND



→ The gap between citation churn and brand stability shows up on every engine.

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FINDING 04 · BY SOURCE TYPE

Vendor site citations last longest. Community / UGC churns fastest.

URL CITATION HALF-LIFE BY SOURCE TYPE



Source type from the cited domain: vendor sites (tracked brands' own domains), review sites, community / UGC (Reddit, YouTube, LinkedIn, Quora…), and everything else.

→ If you want citations that stick, vendor site pages hold on 2.0× longer than community / UGC ones.

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LIMITS · WHAT IT MEANS

Measure the shortlist, not the snapshot.

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS

Report citations on a rolling 4-week window, never a single week.

Make brand mention rate the headline KPI; citations are the evidence underneath it.

Read a lost citation as normal turnover unless it stays gone for 2+ weeks.

LIMITS

14 weekly runs: spells longer than ~13 weeks are censored, so the longest half-lives are lower bounds.

One answer per prompt per engine per week: answer-to-answer variance and true decay can't be fully separated.

Sensitivity: with no flicker tolerance, half-lives drop to 10d (URL) and 50d (brand). The gap holds.

Data: SlateIndex, CC BY 4.0. Analysis by Slate research.